ZULU BATTLE DRESS

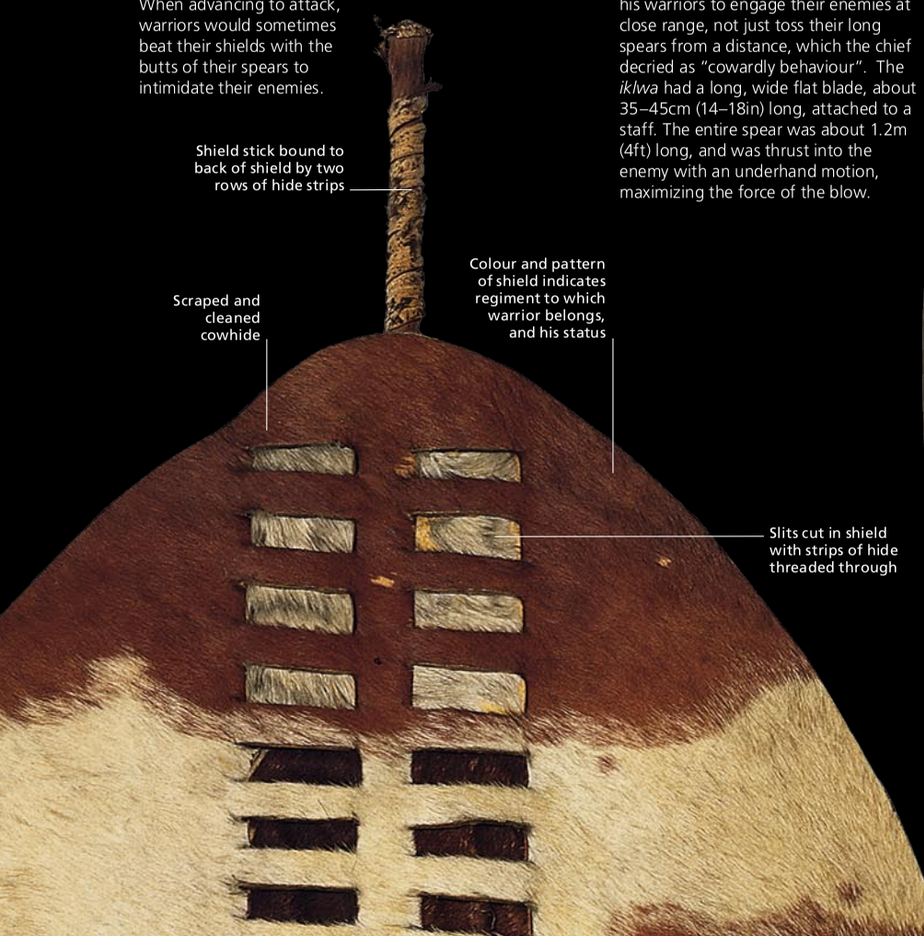
The Zulu warrior's main equipment consisted of a heavy stabbing spear and a large cowhide shield, although the Zulu also carried throwing spears, knobkerries (clubs), and, by the second half of the 19th century, muskets or rifles. Details of dress and decoration of equipment were used to signify status and allegiance. The war shield in particular symbolized the warrior's commitment to his king's service – one Zulu commander referred to the shield as "the love charm of the nation".

Headdress
The warrior's headpiece, to which was attached elaborate feather decorations, was generally a leopard- or otterskin band, set over a monkey skin cap that had neck and ear flaps. This 19th-century example was used for ceremonial purposes.



Zulu war shield
War shields were made from the hides of cattle from the king's herd. The hide was scraped, cleaned, and buried in the soil for several days before being cut to shape. When advancing to attack, warriors would sometimes beat their shields with the butts of their spears to intimidate their enemies.

Iklwa (stabbing spear)
The most devastating Zulu weapon was the *iklwa*, or stabbing spear, said to be named for the sound it made when drawn from a body. The *iklwa* is traditionally said to have been developed by Chief Shaka, who wanted his warriors to engage their enemies at close range, not just toss their long spears from a distance, which the chief decried as "cowardly behaviour". The *iklwa* had a long, wide flat blade, about 35–45cm (14–18in) long, attached to a staff. The entire spear was about 1.2m (4ft) long, and was thrust into the enemy with an underhand motion, maximizing the force of the blow.





> "WE KILLED EVERY WHITE MAN LEFT IN THE CAMP AND THE HORSES AND CATTLE TOO."
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> **GUMPEGA KWABE**, ZULU WARRIOR, ON MASSACRE OF BRITISH AT NTOMBE RIVER, MARCH 1879

